

EUROPE, HISTORY OF



EUROPE HAS PLAYED a much more important role in world history than its small population or size would suggest. The Greeks and Romans colonized large parts of North Africa and western Asia, and from the 15th century onwards, European nations established trading empires that spanned the globe. The Industrial Revolution of the 18th century gave Europe an economic strength which allowed it to dominate world trade, and both World Wars began in Europe. Since 1945, Europe's global influence has declined, as wealth and military power has shifted to North America and Asia.

Christian Europe

In the 4th century, Christianity became the official religion of the Roman empire, and over the next 700 years the faith spread throughout Europe. With the break-up of the Roman empire by 476 and the lack of any strong political force after then, Christianity became the single unifying force across the continent and the church gained great power.



Papal ring

Papacy
As head of the Roman Catholic Church, the popes had enormous spiritual power. Vast landholdings also gave the popes much political power, which led to many conflicts between the papacy and the leading rulers of Europe.



Orthodox icon of the Archangel Gabriel

East and west

Attempts by the pope in Rome to establish his jurisdiction over the entire Christian Church were resisted by the Orthodox Churches of eastern Europe, centred around the ancient city of Constantinople. In 1054, this schism (split) became final, leading to a religious division in Christian Europe that survives to this day.



College built around a central quadrangle

Merton College, one of Oxford's earliest colleges

Growth of education

The Church dominated education, at first through the monasteries and then the universities. The first university in Europe, specializing in medicine, was established at Salerno in southern Italy in the 9th century; others, such as Bologna, Paris, and Oxford, followed later.



The royal coat of arms of Philip II of Spain decorates the cover of one of his books.

Nation state

By the 16th century, centralized national governments had emerged right across Europe, from Spain in the west to Russia in the east. The Holy Roman Empire had begun to break up, and in countries such as England power was concentrated in the hands of the monarch who ruled with the support of a parliament, composed of members of the aristocracy and church.



Religious wars

The creation of new, Protestant Churches in the 16th century divided western Europe. Roman Catholic and Protestant states fought for supremacy in a series of bitter wars which lasted until the middle of the next century.

Henry IV of France was raised Protestant, but later converted to Catholicism.



Prehistoric Europe

The first settlers in Europe were primitive hunters who moved around in search of food. By about 5000 BC, people learned to farm and settled in villages. Bronze-working, and later iron-working, spread across the continent.

Prehistoric "Venus" figurine from Lespugue, France

Civilizations of Europe

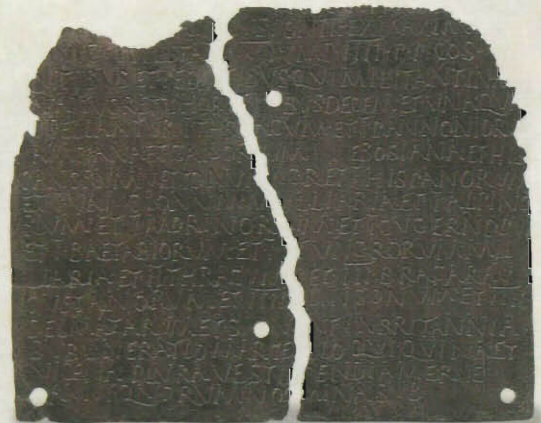
After 900 BC, four civilizations made their successive mark on Europe. The first were the Greeks, who created powerful city states. They were followed a century later by the Etruscans in Italy. By 200 BC the Celts had settled across Europe. Finally the vast and powerful Roman Empire spanned the continent, reaching its height in AD 117.



Ionic-style capital from ancient Greek temple

Greek Europe

The independent city states of ancient Greece got most of their wealth from trade. Their merchants sailed around the Mediterranean, and founded colonies from Spain to the Black Sea. The most powerful Greek cities were Athens and Sparta.



Latin inscription from a Roman tomb

Roman Europe

From its foundation in c.753 BC, the city of Rome gradually expanded its power until, by the first century AD, it controlled most of Europe. The Romans gave Europe a network of roads, a common language (Latin), and a legal system, all of which survived long after the fall of the empire in the 5th century.



Basilica in Goa, India

Overseas empires

In the 15th century, European nations built up empires. Spain and Portugal colonized Central and South America; Britain, France, and the Netherlands colonized North America and the Far East.